

Chapter 177-11

The house immediately fell silent.

Only an aged voice could be heard from the phone receiver: "Your daughter is still alive. Give me one million, and I'll tell you where your daughter is."

"Is that Auntie Wang?" Shen Hui had sharp ears and recognized the voice. She mouthed the question to Shen Fenghe.

Shen Fenghe nodded.

Zhu Mingqi asked: "How can you prove it?"

"Madam, I need money right now. I wouldn't lie to you." Auntie Wang said. "My son is lying in the ICU right now. I need this money. Your daughter really didn't die. The one you buried back then was Sister Guihua's brother's daughter. You were all crying so hard at the time that no one looked closely... Plus the child was already in that state, so Sister Guihua switched them. She had me take the baby and throw her by the garbage bins outside the hospital. That child still had a breath of life in her at the time."

Shen Hui sent a message to Zhao Xuning: 【Something happened at my house.】

Zhao Xuning: 【What?】

Shen Hui: 【A former servant from my family called to extort us.】

Just as her words fell, the doorbell at home rang.

Shen Siyan saw it was Zhao Xuning and sat there without moving.

Shen Hui raised her hand to have the servant open the door.

After Zhao Xuning came in, she didn't dare speak. Shen Hui immediately stood up and pulled her to her side.

They heard the voice on the phone continue: "Madam, really, how would I dare to lie to you? My son is waiting for this money to save his life. I really do know who took your daughter away. Back then, she definitely made a deal with Sister Guihua. I was just momentarily confused and listened to Sister Guihua's words... Anyway, that child was about to die, but unexpectedly she was blessed with good fortune and is actually still alive."

"Then why don't you go extort her?" Zhu Mingqi questioned coldly.

Auntie Wang was stunned, then said in a choked voice: "Madam, I haven't been able to reach her phone for a long time. She told me that child had died and had already been thrown into the sea. But I saw the news these past few days and realized everything she said was lies. Madam, I'm not lying to you. Please save my child's life."

Zhao Xuning had come in partway through, but she'd heard most of it. She asked Shen Hui in a low voice.

Shen Hui leaned close to her ear and explained the whole story.

Zhao Xuning's expression changed slightly.

In the end, Zhu Mingqi agreed and had someone wire her one million.

Auntie Wang wasn't stupid either. She said she would tell her daughter's whereabouts once the one million was transferred to her account.

After Zhu Mingqi hung up the phone, she braced herself weakly against the table, nearly collapsing.

Shen Yaobo supported her, giving her something to lean on.

Zhu Mingqi was about to tell the butler to wire the money to Auntie Wang when Zhao Xuning called out: "Wait."

The whole family looked at her in unison.

Zhao Xuning was the type who only hesitated at the moment of making a choice, but was very decisive once she'd made her decision. So she said cleanly and clearly: "I know where she is."

Everyone was shocked.

Shen Hui grabbed her wrist. "What nonsense are you talking?"

"I'm not talking nonsense." Zhao Xuning held her hand in return, but her gaze was directed at Zhu Mingqi. "Would you want to acknowledge her?"

Zhu Mingqi pressed her lips together: "She's really still alive?"

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Alive, and very healthy."

Gu Yixue seemed to have already understood something. She scrolled through today's trending searches, found the costume photos from Liang Shi's "Journey of the Heart" from before, looked at the photo, then glanced at Shen Fenghe.

Then she silently placed her phone in front of Shen Fenghe.

Shen Fenghe was still listening to Zhao Xuning speak. Seeing Gu Yixue do this, she lowered her head to look.

In an instant, enlightenment struck.

"She went and got a DNA test done, so it's real." Zhao Xuning came clean with them directly. "But I don't know what her concerns were—she kept this matter hidden. It's been over a month now. Today, she ran into some trouble, and she's still at the top of the trending searches."

Shen Hui was stunned: "Huh?"

Everyone was shocked, but Shen Hui was the only one who made a sound.

Zhao Xuning looked down at her, saw her dazed expression, pinched her face, then quickly let go.

Shen Hui opened the trending searches and found Liang Shi's name there.

She clicked in and out, her shock evident on her face.

Shen Yaobo and Zhu Mingqi both opened their phones.

Shen Siyan stared at the screen, still in disbelief: "You're lying to us, right?"

Zhao Xuning showed them the DNA test report images that Liang Shi had sent her before, using the data to prove its authenticity.

Shen Hui raised a question: "How did she get the samples?"

Zhao Xuning told them truthfully about what happened that day.

But she also glossed over some unspeakable details.

The reason she was able to get Shen Hui's hair that day was because Shen Hui had come to see her. As they talked, Shen Hui had gotten so angry she cried.

She didn't know how to comfort her, so she went forward and hugged her, then leaned down to kiss Shen Hui. Her fingers slid into her long hair, and when the kiss ended, she casually plucked out a strand of hair.

As for how Liang Shi got that white hair of hers, she had no idea.

But Zhu Mingqi remembered what happened that day.

She felt somewhat dazed. "No wonder I always felt she was so familiar... I kept wanting her to be my daughter-in-law."

Gu Yixue & Zhao Xuning: "?"

Zhu Mingqi's eyes had already reddened. Before she could fully process everything, Auntie Wang's call came through again.

"Madam, why haven't you wired the money yet? Don't you want to know where your daughter is?" Auntie Wang's tone was anxious.

Zhu Mingqi let out a light breath. "I'll only give you two hundred thousand. Tell me clearly who Yang Gui¹ was colluding with, how you committed the crime, and how you switched the babies—explain everything to me one by one."

"Two hundred thousand won't work, Madam. It won't save my son's life." Auntie Wang was still bargaining.

"I'll count to ten." Zhu Mingqi's tone was cold and harsh. "If you haven't told me by then, I won't give you a single cent. I already know who my daughter is now, and I'll go find her. But your son is in the ICU—he can't wait."

Footnotes:

¹ Yang Gui (楊桂) - Also referred to as "Sister Guihua" (桂花姐) in the conversation. "Guihua" is her given name, and Yang is her surname. She appears to be the mastermind servant who orchestrated the baby switch.